

ANI

FIRED UP (From extreme left) The burnt remains of Fatik Sheikh's house at Bagtui village of Birbhum district; CM Mamata Banerjee meets family members of the deceased

was shot dead apparently because he refused to join the TMC and help the latter form the board in the municipality. Audio clips, allegedly of local station in-charge Sanjib Ghosh, are doing the rounds, implicating the police.

It was the carnage on March 28, though, that put the state back in the national headlines, and for all the wrong reasons. It also gave the opposition BJP another opportunity to raise the 'anarchy and lawlessness' bogey, a pet excuse to clamour for presidential rule in Bengal (governor Jagdeep Dhankhar's latest salvo on Twitter called the Birbhum incident an "arson orgy").

Politics aside, the string of incidents of political violence, starting with the mayhem following the 2021 election results, throws open the big question of whether Mamata's writ still runs in the state's hinterland. The Bagtui incident appears to be retaliation for the murder of the powerful deputy head of Barshol gram panchayat, Bhadu Sheikh, once again exposing the soft underbelly of the politician-criminal-police nexus.

Way back in 2012, Bhadu, sometime chicken transporter-turned-*dakmaster* (euphemism for extortionist) for the local police, started harbouring political ambitions and joined the Trinamool, which had just come to power. He soon got close to TMC district president and Birbhum strongman Anubrata Mondal and began using his muscle to 'collect funds' for the party. While Bhadu and his cohorts looked after resource mobilisation, another character, Anarul Hossain, who is now in jail as co-accused in the retaliatory killings, was in charge of party organisation.

The buzz is that Bhadu was reneging on money that was to be kicked back upstairs to the higher-ups. There's also talk of a fallout with some of his aides, again over money. That said, who killed Bhadu and what led to the Bagtui incident are matters for investigation but why districts like Birbhum are fast turning into killing fields is not too difficult to guess.

The area is abundant in sand and stone (basalt stone and stone chips). "Illegal stone and sand mining supplies material to 85 per cent of the construction sites in the cities. It also fills the pockets of a long chain of conduits, from politicians to police to local level thugs. Earnings from some areas like, say, Nalhati, which has 11 illegal stone pits, is between Rs 70-90 lakh daily from one major arterial exit alone," says a local transport operator on condition of anonymity.

THE BIRBHUM CARNAGE OPENS UP THE QUESTION OF WHETHER MAMATA'S WRIT STILL RUNS IN THE HINTERLAND

The CBI's entry, far from bringing a sense of relief, has muddled the situation further. A 35-member team is camping at Tarapith in Rampurhat now. Along with the CBI, the state BJP unit is also now active in the area. A five-member fact-finding mission has done the rounds, as has a team of state MLAs.

The Trinamool is already crying vendetta. Mamata is talking of a larger central conspiracy to malign the image of the state. Party spokesperson Kunal Ghosh points to how the CM has fulfilled her *rajdharma* by arresting 22 people, including Anarul. "The chief minister has brought to book all those who were negligent in their duties. She has taken action against the police and even the TMC block president. The way the BJP and CBI are acting in Rampurhat, it's as if they are working in tandem. If our leaders are intercepted on purpose, we will take to the streets," Ghosh warned.

Mamata too echoed the street battle chorus; it is likely to be the party strategy to take on the Centre if the CBI "intentionally" closes in on party leaders. The CM has already written a letter on March 29 to various leaders of the opposition camp, asking that they come together urgently against the BJP and its use of central agencies to 'harass political opponents'.

The Centre would do well not to overplay its hand now, give any cause for Mamata to play out her "vendetta politics" card. Getting Mamata out on the streets, her favourite battleground, could turn up the heat even in capital Delhi, in what is already looking like a long hot summer. ■